12. The Land I Will Show You

Passage: Genesis 12:1–9 (the passage, with notes on the Hebrew)

Last week ended on one word: *Go*. Today Abram goes. In nine verses he walks more than four hundred miles, builds two altars, pitches a tent — and never says a word.

One thread runs through the whole passage, and it starts in the first sentence. God tells Abram exactly what to leave — *your country, your relatives, your father's household* — and almost nothing about where he is going: *"to the land that I will show you."* Then he doesn't show him. Not yet. Today we follow that thread, and ask what it means for people like us, who also have to start down roads before we can see where they go.

> ***1*** *Now the LORD said to Abram, "Go out from your country, your relatives, and your father's household to the land that I will show you.* ***2*** *Then I will make you into a great nation, and I will bless you, and I will make your name great, so that you will exemplify divine blessing.* ***3*** *I will bless those who bless you, but the one who treats you lightly I must curse, so that all the families of the earth may receive blessing through you."*
>
> ***4*** *So Abram left, just as the LORD had told him to do, and Lot went with him. (Now Abram was 75 years old when he departed from Haran.)* ***5*** *And Abram took his wife Sarai, his nephew Lot, and all the possessions they had accumulated and the people they had acquired in Haran, and they left for the land of Canaan. They entered the land of Canaan.* ***6*** *Abram traveled through the land as far as the oak tree of Moreh at Shechem. (At that time the Canaanites were in the land.)* ***7*** *The LORD appeared to Abram and said, "To your descendants I will give this land." So Abram built an altar there to the LORD, who had appeared to him.* ***8*** *Then he moved from there to the hill country east of Bethel and pitched his tent, with Bethel on the west and Ai on the east. There he built an altar to the LORD and worshiped the LORD.* ***9*** *Abram continually journeyed by stages down to the Negev.*

1. Settled halfway (11:31)

The call does not come out of a clear sky. Read the verse just before it:

> *Terah took his son Abram, his grandson Lot… and his daughter-in-law Sarai… and with them he set out from Ur of the Chaldeans to go to Canaan. When they came to Haran, they settled there. (11:31)*

The family was already on the road to Canaan, and it stopped. *They settled there* is word for word what the builders did at Babel (11:2). Haran was an easy place to stop: a rich city on the trade road, some six hundred miles up the Euphrates from Ur, and like Ur a city of the moon god. (Joshua remembers that Terah's family *"worshiped other gods,"* Joshua 24:2.) They had moved. They had not left.

Stephen adds what Genesis leaves out: God had already spoken to Abram back in Mesopotamia, *"before he settled in Haran"* (Acts 7:2–4; compare Genesis 15:7). Put the two together and the story is more ordinary, and more hopeful, than the one we often tell. We picture a lightning bolt: God called, Abram went. Genesis and Stephen tell of a man who heard God, set out, and stopped halfway with his family — for years. Then God said it again: *Go.*

Jewish storytellers felt that pause. In *Jubilees*, written about two centuries before Christ, Abram sits up one night in Haran watching the stars, and prays:

> *Shall I return unto Ur of the Chaldees who seek my face that I may return to them, or am I to remain here in this place? The right path before Thee prosper it in the hands of Thy servant… (Jubilees 12:21)*

The answer is not a map. It is *"Get thee up from thy country."* When Abram tells his father, Terah blesses him and stays behind: *"if thou seest a land pleasant to thy eyes to dwell in, then arise and take me to thee"* (12:30). Terah will come once the land has been seen. Abram has to go first.

Most of us know Haran: where we set out toward something God put in front of us — a calling, a reconciliation, a change — and settled short, often for good reasons: family, grief, fear. Genesis does not scold Terah. It only tells us where his road ended: *"he died in Haran"* (11:32). And it shows God speaking again to someone who had stopped.

> **Talk about it.** Where is your Haran — somewhere you set out toward and settled short of? What made it a comfortable place to stop?

2. "The land that I will show you" (12:1–5)

God names exactly what Abram must leave, and nothing about where he is going. The verb is ***ʾarʾekkā***, "I will make you see" — future tense. Why not say where? The rabbis asked:

> *Why did he not reveal it [his destination] to him? It was to make it more endearing to him, and to give him a reward for each and every stride. (Rabbi Yoḥanan, in Genesis Rabbah 39:9)*

And in the same breath:

> *The Holy One blessed be He withholds [information at first] and keeps the eyes of the righteous directed toward Him, and only then does he reveal to them the particulars of the matter. (Rav Huna, in Genesis Rabbah 39:9)*

Not knowing where you are going keeps your eyes on the one who does. Rav Huna's next example is the only other place in the Bible that says ***lek-lәḵā***, "Go": Abraham sent to Moriah, *"on one of the mountains which I will indicate to you"* (22:2). Hebrews says it plainly: *"he went out without understanding where he was going"* (11:8).

Not knowing is not having nothing. Abram had a word from God, a direction (the family had always been heading for Canaan), and people beside him — among them *"the people they had acquired in Haran,"* literally *"the souls they had made."* The rabbis heard converts: *"Abraham converted the men and Sarah converted the women"* (Genesis Rabbah 39:14). *"So Abram left, just as the LORD had told him to do"* (12:4). He is seventy-five, and he does not say a word.

Hear 12:5 against 11:31 — in Hebrew, the same sentence until the last words:

Terah (11:31)	**Abram (12:5)**
they set out… *to go to the land of Canaan,*	they set out *to go to the land of Canaan,*
and they came as far as Haran — and settled there.	*and they came* to the land of Canaan.

The Zohar, the great medieval book of Jewish mysticism, noticed that God's *Go* comes right after the family set out *"to go to the land of Canaan,"* and drew the lesson: the word came after Abram made the first move. Sometimes God shows the way first; in the wilderness, Israel moved only when the cloud moved (Numbers 9:17–18). But sometimes the word is simply *Go*, and the seeing comes on the road. Often the first step is how we get the map.

> **Talk about it.** Have you ever had to start before you could see where it led? What did you learn on the road that you could not have learned before you set out?

3. "The LORD appeared" (12:6–7)

Abram walks on *"as far as the oak tree of Moreh at Shechem. (At that time the Canaanites were in the land.)"* ***Moreh*** means "teacher," or "one who points the way" — the root of *Torah*. A great tree with that name was probably a holy place where people came for answers. And the land God promised to show him is already full.

Then: *"The LORD appeared to Abram."* In Hebrew, ***wayyērāʾ*** — the same verb as *I will show you*. *"I will make you see"* becomes *"he let himself be seen."* It is the first time in the Bible that God *appears* to anyone, and it comes at the end of the road, not the beginning: more than four hundred miles after Haran. Ramban, the great medieval commentator, pictured Abram crossing the land afraid, with Canaanites all around and no land yet shown, until at Shechem *"G-d appeared to him and gave him the land, and as a result his fear departed from him… and then he built an altar to G-d in order to worship Him openly."*

What is Abram shown? Not a map. A promise: *"To your descendants I will give this land"* — said to a seventy-five-year-old whose wife is barren (11:30), on ground where *"the Canaanites were in the land."* The showing does not clear away the obstacles; it names the impossible thing and promises it anyway. Abram himself, Stephen says, was given *"not even a foot of ground"* (Acts 7:5).

4. An altar, a tent, and the road (12:7–9)

Abram answers with an altar *"to the LORD, who had appeared to him"* — the first since Noah's. He moves on, pitches his tent between Bethel and Ai, builds a second altar, and *"worshiped the LORD"* — literally, he *called on the name of the LORD* (4:26). Babel baked bricks for a tower and a name; Abram piles stones for God's name, and lives in a tent. And the passage ends: *"Abram continually journeyed by stages down to the Negev"* — ***hālôḵ wənāsôaʿ***, "going on and pulling up stakes." No *settled there*. He is still walking.

The first hearers knew every place he stopped. Jacob would build an altar at Shechem (33:20) and dream at Bethel (28:19); Joshua would fight at Ai and renew the covenant at Shechem (Joshua 8; 24). Rashi says Abram was praying ahead for his children: at Shechem *"on behalf of Jacob's sons,"* at Ai because *"his descendants would once stumble… there."* Ramban made it a rule for all the stories of the fathers: *"Whatever has happened to the patriarchs is a sign to the children."* When the exiles in Babylon were free to go home — the same road, to a land full of other people — the prophet told them: *"Look at Abraham, your father… When I summoned him, he was a lone individual, but I blessed him and gave him numerous descendants"* (Isaiah 51:2). Not all of them went. Josephus says *"many of them stay[ed] at Babylon; as not willing to leave their possessions."*

We walk ahead of other people too — children, grandchildren, the people beside us today. The altars we build along the road, the places where we stop and call on God's name, are where they will find him after us.

Next week

Famine (12:10). Abram goes down to Egypt — with no word from God and no altar — and his first recorded words are a scheme. Walking before you can see is one thing. Walking without a word is another.

So what?

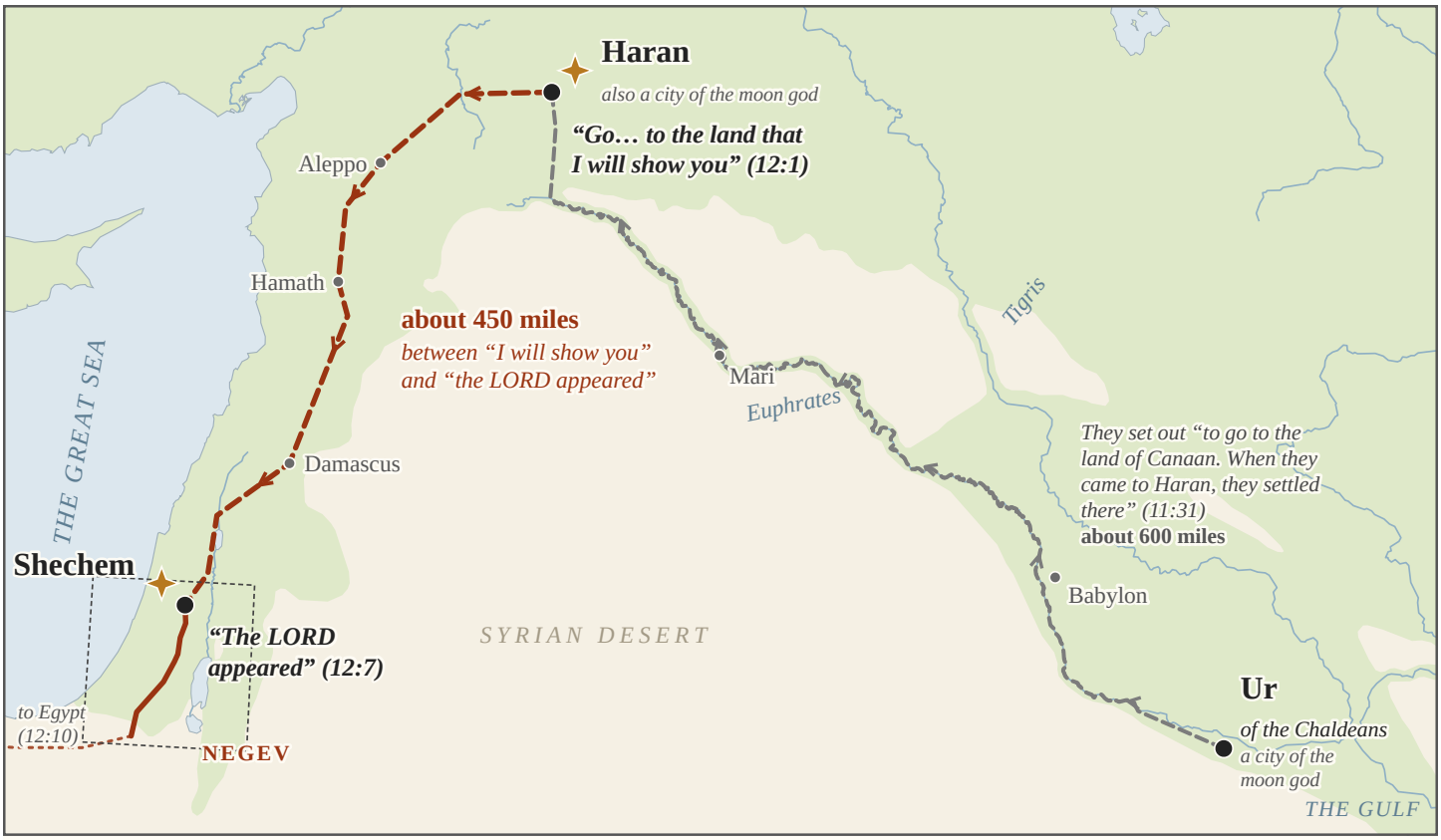
1. God speaks again to people who have stopped. Abram had settled halfway. God said *Go* a second time.

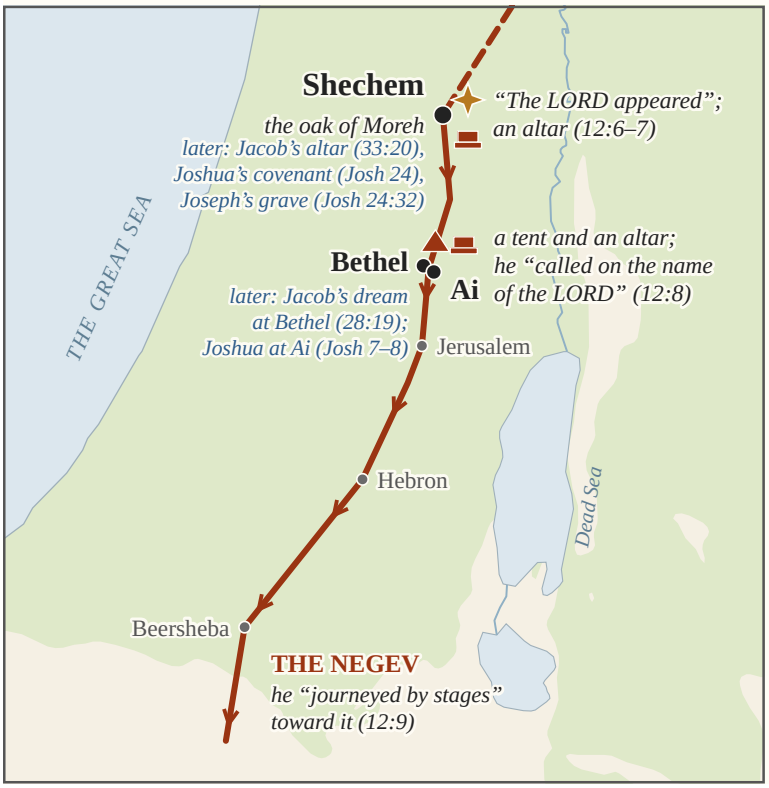
2. The word comes before the map. The rabbis said the land was hidden to make it dear, to count every step, and to keep Abram's eyes on God.

3. The seeing comes on the road — usually as a promise, not a plan. At Shechem God showed Abram a gift he would not hold himself, and his fear left him.

4. Walk with an altar and a tent. Worship where you stop; hold the camp lightly; someone is walking behind you.

> **Talk about it — to close.** What step in front of you are you waiting to see past before you take it? What would it look like to take it this week — and where will you build your altar?





Abram's road

Genesis 11:31–12:9

- Terah's family, Ur to Haran (11:31)
- Abram, Haran to Shechem (12:4–6)
- Abram in the land (12:6–9)
- God speaks (12:1, 7)
- an altar (12:7, 8)
- a tent (12:8)
- *Aa* later on the same ground
- fertile land, watered by rain or river

On foot, roughly

Ur to Haran	about 600 miles
Haran to Shechem	about 450 miles
Shechem to Bethel and Ai	about 20 miles
Bethel to the Negev	about 70 miles

Genesis names no stop between Haran and Shechem; the dashed road follows the main route. Places: Pleiades (CC BY); climate zones: Beck et al. 2023 (CC BY 4.0); coastlines and rivers are modern.

Abram's road. *Above:* with his father from Ur up the Euphrates to Haran (11:31), then on his own south to Shechem (12:4–6). The stars mark where God speaks: *"I will show you"* at Haran, *"the LORD appeared"* at Shechem. Genesis does not say which road Abram took from Haran; this one follows the main road through Aleppo and Damascus. *Below:* the land, 12:6–9 — two altars, a tent, and the road on toward the Negev; in blue, what later happened at the same places. Green is land watered by rain or river. Sources for every place on Abram's road on the ground.